

Kaitiaki of the Stream

*by Pātaka Moore and
Monique Lagan*

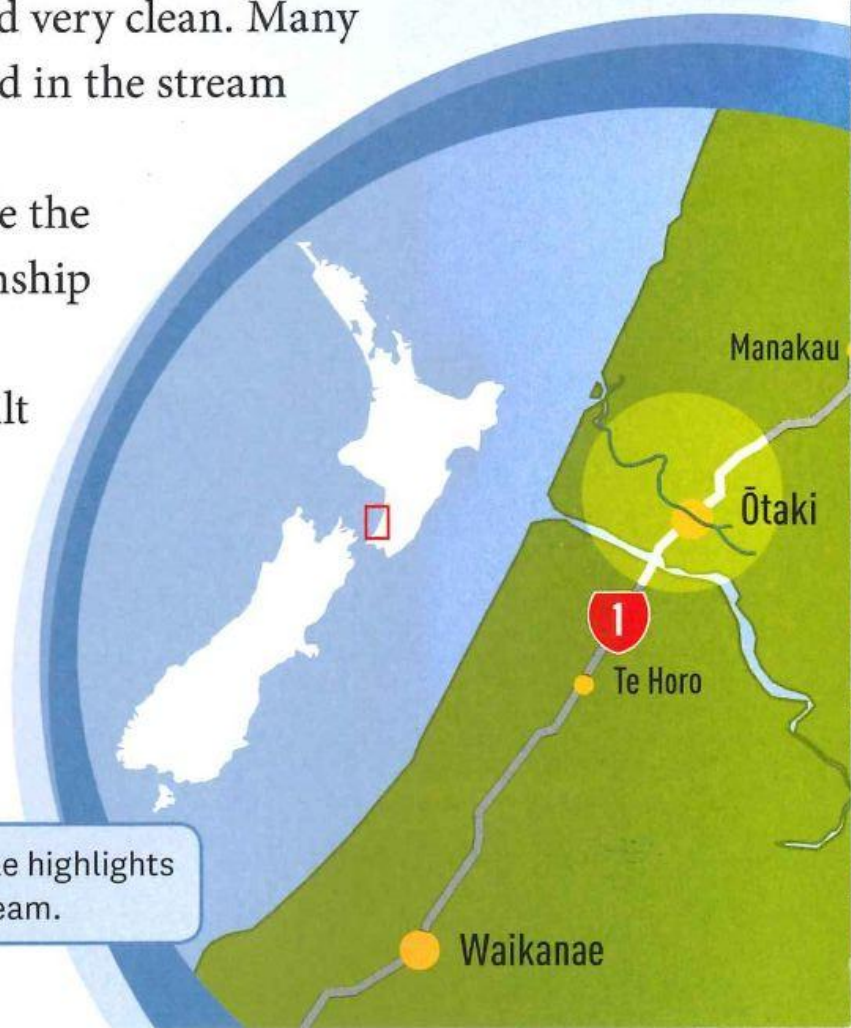


Pātaka Moore (Ngāti Pareraukawa, Ngāti Raukawa) has a strong interest in the environment. He is studying the Mangapōuri Stream, which flows through his hometown of Ōtaki on the Kāpiti Coast. The stream is very polluted. Pātaka is talking to people about the importance of the stream and how it could be made healthy again. Recently, he spoke to a group of local students ...



The Mangapōuri Stream is very special to the hapū and community of Ōtaki. It used to be slow-flowing, very clear, and very clean. Many fish, insects, and plants lived in the stream and on its banks.

Three marae grew beside the stream, along with the township of Ōtaki, and a number of schools. A mill was also built nearby. It used the water to drive a large waterwheel, which ground wheat to make flour.



The light-green circle highlights the Mangapōuri Stream.



Why is the stream important?

From early times, Māori lived on the banks of the Mangapōuri Stream. The stream was a source of fresh, clean water for drinking and bathing. It was also an important source of food. Īnanga (whitebait), tuna (eel), kōura (freshwater crayfish), and kōkopu (native trout) all lived in the stream in large numbers.

Māori also used the stream as a sort of “fridge”. The cool water was a good place to store kai, including the much-loved kānga wai (fermented corn). The corn was put into the water in baskets and boxes to keep it cold and fresh. Tuna were also stored alive in the stream until it was time to eat them.

Tuna were a very important part of the Māori diet because they are such a good source of protein. Every year around December, Māori would prepare their tuna boxes and repair their nets to get ready for the tuna heke. This is the time in autumn when adult tuna swim out to sea to breed. The tuna heke usually happens over one or two nights during an autumn rain.



Fat tuna!

Adult tuna swim thousands of kilometres to lay their eggs in the warmer waters of the South Pacific, and then they die. The journey can take them several months. After the eggs hatch, the tiny tuna float back to New Zealand on the ocean currents.

The adult tuna do not eat at all during the entire journey. Instead, they rely on fat stored inside their bodies to keep them going. This means that when the tuna are caught and stored in the stream, they don't have to be fed.



Until about thirty years ago, the Mangapōuri Stream and other waterways in the Kāpiti area were full of tuna, so they were easy to catch during the tuna heke. After they were caught, the tuna were put into large storage boxes in the stream. When a family wanted fresh fish, they would visit the box and pull out a tuna. Each whānau had its own pā tuna (eel trap), its own tuna box, and its own ways of catching and preparing tuna. This information was handed down from generation to generation.





What's happened to the stream?

Today, the Mangapōuri Stream isn't as healthy as it used to be. People can't bathe or swim in the water, and there's much less food in the stream. There are a number of reasons why:

- Storm water pollution: This is the rainwater that comes off the roads and washes into the stream. It carries poisons that are not good for the stream's health.
- Bush removal: Much of the bush that was once beside the stream has been removed. The bush helped to stop soil from washing into the stream. Now the stream bottom is covered with mud. This prevents the insects and fish that live there from feeding. The bush also shaded the stream from the hot sun. When the sun shines on the stream, it heats the water. Many fish and insects cannot live in water that is too warm.

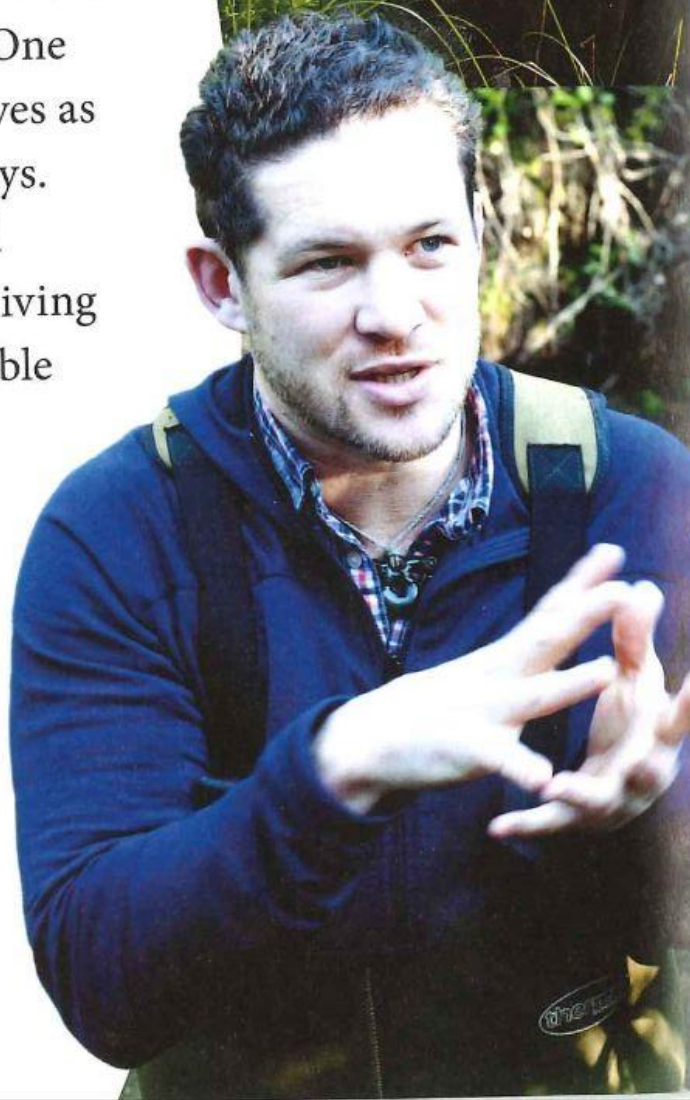
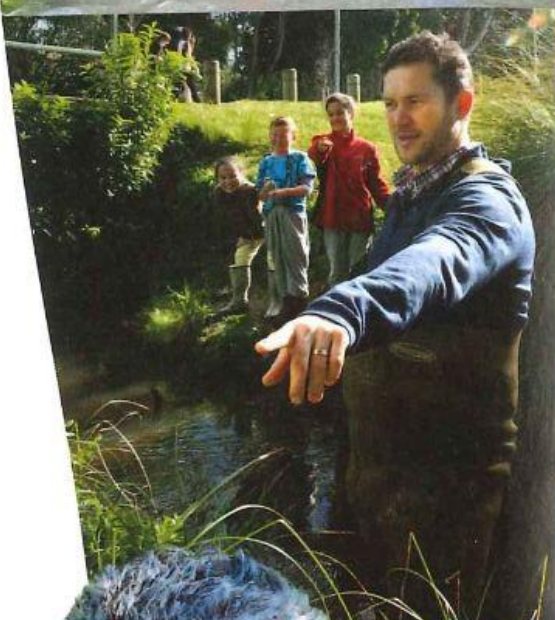


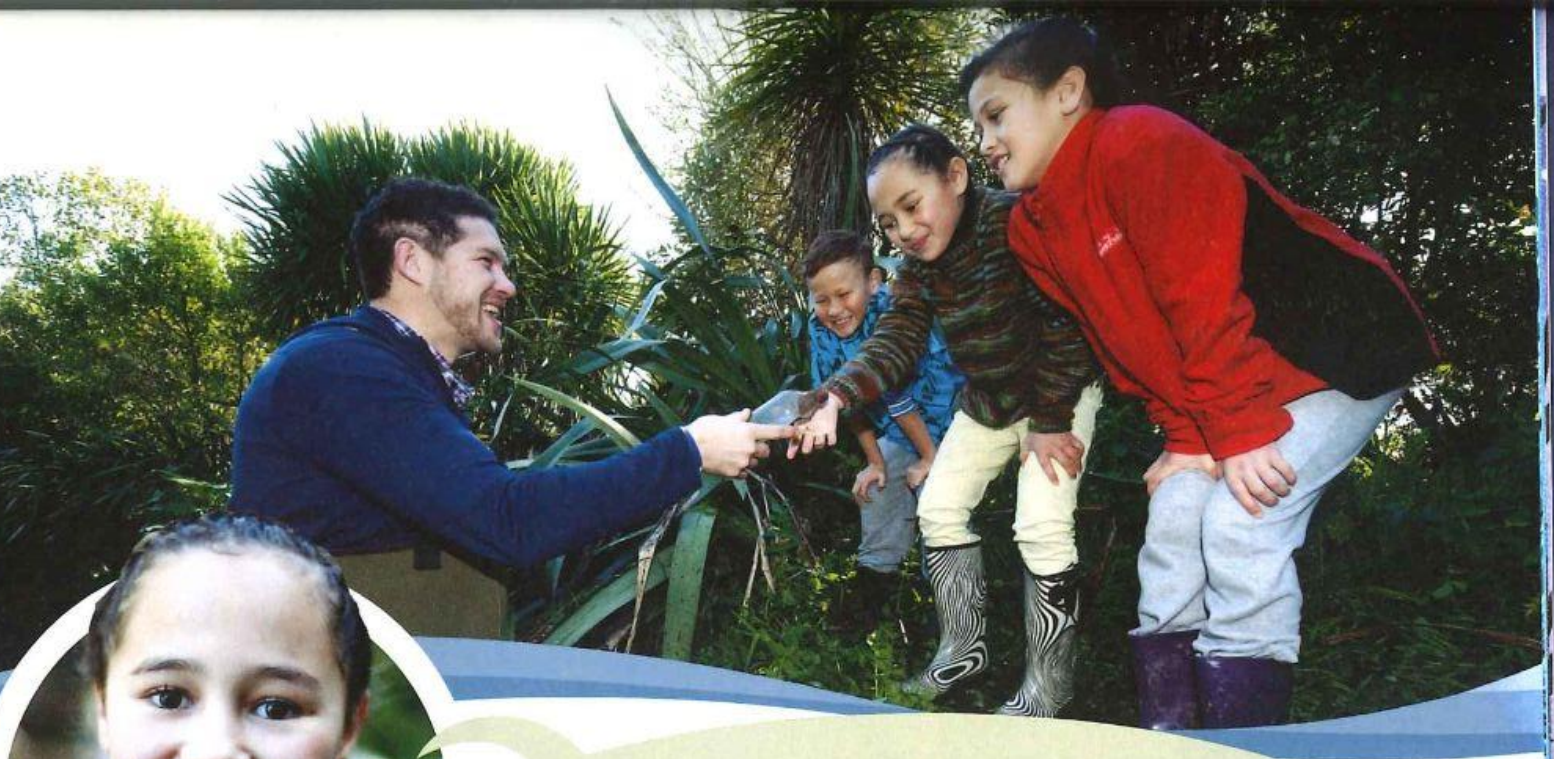
- Fertiliser run-off: Fertilisers from farms can cause weeds and algae to grow in the stream. These use a lot of oxygen, leaving less for the other plants and animals living in the stream. All animals and plants need oxygen to survive.

What can we do to help the stream?

The community and the local Māori who live nearby want to save the Mangapōuri Stream. They are working to make their local stream healthy again.

What can we do to keep our local rivers and streams in a healthy condition? One thing we can do is to think of ourselves as kaitiaki or guardians of our waterways. Kaitiakitanga is about caring for and protecting our environment and all living creatures. We all need to be responsible for streams like the Mangapōuri. Then we can enjoy our waterways, and future generations will be able to enjoy them, too.





Plant native trees and bushes along stream banks. This will help to shade the stream and stop mud and dirt from entering it.

Don't litter. When we leave rubbish behind, some of it can find its way into our streams. Litter is not good for the health of a stream and the life in it.



Treat the environment with respect. Respect our fish and other creatures so they will continue to survive.



Mā pango, mā whero, ka oti ai te mahi.
When we co-operate and work together, we can get the job done.